Kyoto Protocol.

The UN Climate Change Conferences have never been able to register historical breakthroughs ever since their initiation chiefly because of the North-South divide on climate change and other environment issues. Consensus among the participating countries is always difficult. The Kyoto Protocol has been only a major achievement, but negotiations for the post-Kyoto successor are proving to be a stumbling block. The Copenhagen Conference 2009 could not hammer out a new treaty.

Again, the differences between the developing countries and developed countries came to the fore. The developing countries, least developed countries and small island countries refused to budge from their position and reiterated the historical responsibility of the developed countries for maximum greenhouse emission. They demanded that climate change action should be guided by principles of historical responsibility and common and differentiated responsibility. They also wanted the extension of the Kyoto Protocol which gives some relief to developing countries. However, the US and the developed countries wanted to replace the Kyoto Protocol whereby cuts in emission of greenhouse gases become applicable to poor countries too and also wanted large emitters like India and China to be more transparent about domestic emission curbing actions. India did not shift her position during the Copenhagen negotiations, but clauses in the Accord suggest that emission cut by her even those not supported by foreign finance may be open to international consultations. Further, there was no agreement on designing a legally binding instrument that will govern climate change beyond 2012. Thus, the Copenhagen Accord has failed to deliver the goods to the countries of the South, and many feel that there is a tilt towards the developed countries.

The Cancun Conference, 2010 also could not be said to be successful in delivering the goods to the world. The Cancun documents recognize emission targets set by industrialized and developing countries and require that inventories of the national emissions are shared annually by industrialized countries and once every two years by the developing countries. The agreements are expected to be transformed into a legal treaty at next December